



Striking showdown: Puja Tomar delivers a powerful kick to Shauna Bannon at UFC Fight Night in London, showcasing her striking prowess in the strawweight division.

from the competition after he wasn't released from his contract by MFN, India's premier promotion, where he holds the lightweight championship.

"We're seeing a situation where, on one hand, some fighters are deciding to step up to a level of competition they aren't really ready for, and at the same time, some of the best Indian fighters for different reasons aren't getting the chance to step up at the right stage of their

careers," Somesh says.

While other observers agree with Somesh's points, they add that it's unfair to judge Indian MMA by the standards of regions where the sport is far more developed. "We have to understand that MMA is still in a very nascent stage in India compared to the USA, where the sport has been around for over a quarter of a century. (For perspective, UFC 1 was held in the USA in 1993, while the

Super Fight League — India's first televised MMA promotion — launched nearly 20 years later in 2012.) There's a whole generation of fighters who have already fought and made careers in MMA in places that we consider strong in the sport. We have Anshul and Puja, but they have hundreds of people who started doing this 10-15 years ago," says Peeyush Pandey, one of India's youngest MMA coaches at 28, who